

The Voice

June 2024



A NEWSLETTER FOR MEMBERS AND FRIENDS OF FIRST EVANGELICAL LUTHERAN CHURCH

*A Congregation of the
Northeastern
Minnesota Synod, ELCA*

The Great Dechurching

Who's Leaving? Why Are They Going, and What We Can Do to Bring Them Back?



Jim Davis and
Michael Graham

with Ryan P. Dunge
Foreword by Colin Hanks

**Recommendations,
page 9.**



**FLW makes plans
page 5.**



Pastor Christie presides over the Pentecost service at Camp Vermilion, wrapping up the council retreat. The focus of the retreat was to work on how to further First Lutheran's mission to grow. They worked hard, but had a good time of fellowship, as well. More photos can be found on page 7.

From the Pastor's Desk

"Remember your creator in the days of your youth" -Ecclesiastes 12:1

"Let them remember that there is meaning beyond absurdity. Let them be sure that every deed counts, that every word has power, and that we all can do our share to redeem the world in spite of all absurdities and all frustrations and all disappointments. And above all let them remember...to build a life as if it were a work of art. Just to be a blessing. Just to live is holy.

*--Rabbi Abraham Joshua Herschel in an interview
describing his message for young people*

Dear ones,

As summer approaches, we have wrapped up our 2023-24 confirmation program for the year. I wanted to write and say a huge thank you to everyone who participated with us and our youth in their learning and in their walk of faith! It was my first time being a part of the youth ministry at First, and it was a blast! We learned about liturgy and parables and service to the community and so much more! None of this of course happens on its own, so there are some big thank you's to share! First, to our adult leaders: Nancy McBride, Joe Belanger and BettyJeanne Henrickson—you have been amazing guides with our students in so many ways—you are a gift they will have for always—thank you! To our students and families: I know you have a lot on your plates with school, sports, work and so many wonderful things that take you all over the place! Such is life of families these days. Thank you for making confirmation ministry and worship a priority and a practice. The vibrancy and joy you all bring to First Lutheran adds so much color and flavor to this place and is a picture of God's work in action. To all our volunteers and members who have stopped in to help with projects, pray for this ministry and cheer it on, as well as to our council who continues to make this ministry a priority—thank you for your support!

The church is a multi-generational family—a family that comes together in support of one another, in learning and to deepen our faith. What a joy to see the contribution of each person! You are the hands and feet of God in so many unique and wonderful ways!

I'd also like to say that just because our confirmation classes aren't in session doesn't mean we don't have any more youth programming! VBS is coming up the second week of June. Be sure to stop by and check out all the fun!

We have students attending summer camp at Camp Hiawatha, and of course the ELCA youth gathering will be happening in July! Finally, and in addition to all this, we hope to have a few fun intergenerational gatherings throughout the summer—stay tuned.

Peace to you all in these summer days and in your walk of faith, no matter your age or stage in life. As Rabbi Herschel rightly says, *"Remember... just to live is holy."*

Your friend in Christ, Pastor Christie



First Evangelical Lutheran Church Council Meeting April 18th, 2024

Present: Treasurer Brad Ettestad, Secretary Carol Bass, Building & Grounds Lloyd Skogstad, Discipleship BettyJeanne Henrickson, Service/Outreach Brenda Bertilson, Pastor Christie Manisto, Fellowship Cynthia Warren, Worship & Music Rachel Hasbargen Glowack

Absent: President Brian Briggs

Meeting called to order by Treasurer Brad Ettestad at 6:00 PM.

Devotion: BettyJeanne Henrickson read Longfellow's "Arrows in the Air" concerning the lasting impact of words.

Next month's Devotion: Pastor will do it at our retreat.

Addition to Agenda: Need to do employee evaluations for office staff.

Minutes from March meeting: Copies provided to all. No corrections or additions.

Motion: To accept the minutes of the March 2024 meeting.

Made by: Cynthia Warren Seconded by: Brenda Bertilson

Carried

Treasurer Report: We broke even financially last month due to Easter/Holy Week donations. Continue to monitor expenses.

Motion: To accept treasurer's report for March 2024.

Made by: Pastor Christie Manisto Seconded by: BettyJeanne Henrickson

Carried

Pastor's Report March 22-April 18

Pastoral acts

☐ Led worship including Easter and preaching over at Fort Frances

☐ visitation and pastoral care phone calls, meetings and cards with members

☐ 2 funerals: Lori Awe's on April 13th and Deanna Rassmussen on March 30th

☐ Bible study and a new book study

☐ 2 new member classes (reception on May 12th)

☐ visited homebound folks on Maundy Thursday with bulletins, communion, and Easter surprises with BettyJeanne.

Community

☐ Continuing to serve as part of the Rotary

welcoming community team. Meetings continue.

☐ Part of an ELCA cohort group meeting on Thursdays each week for 1 hour.

☐ taking a class on Thursday from Wartburg seminary called dialog works on transitions in ministry.

Youth

☐ Sent 2 first families' newsletters.

☐ National youth gathering meetings and fundraising planning including brunch on Palm Sunday (we have reached our goal! thanks to our parents and BettyJeanne and Kathi)

☐ Planning a "senior Sunday" to honor our graduating seniors on May 5th. Each student will receive an Amazon gift card for \$25 and there will be a cake during coffee hour.

☐ On May 1st will be taking the confirmation students to Servants of Shelter. They will be bringing an "evening snack" to the residents as a service project with funds they won at the chili cook off.

Synod

☐ Pastor's text study Trinity in Cook

☐ Mutual ministry meeting in Cook

☐ Conference presentation here at First- Steve and I did our Cairo presentation (thanks to Cynthia for providing fellowship).

☐ Will attend the zoom synod assembly with Steve our voting member on April 27 th (all day)

Council—continued on page 4

Reverend Christie Manisto

Office Hours:

Monday—Thursday

10 a.m. – 2 p.m.

Friday

9 a.m. to noon

218-283-2208

www.firstlutheranifalls.org

firstlutheranifalls@gmail.com

(Council from page 3)

Admin

☐ Committee meetings (finance, building and grounds, care corps etc.)

☐ adjunct meeting with council re: exploration team

Personal

Life is good!

Upcoming

April 21 Youth dinner/drawing/silent auction

☐ April 25 VLM board meeting

☐ April 27 th Synod Assembly

☐ May 5 th senior Sunday

☐ May 18-19 council retreat

Committee Reports:

President – Absent

Vice-President – Position is vacant. Several people have been approached but there is no one who has committed yet.

Service/Outreach – Brenda reported there were 6 volunteers at the community café, and as numbers being served are down, will only need 3-4 in future. 5 get-well cards sent, 1 soup delivered, 3 people put on prayer chain. Food drive collected 238.15 pounds of food, \$500 was donated by FLW, plus a \$150 donation, and \$154 from chili cook off. Suggestions for a project for Gods Work, Our Hands would be appreciated, Cynthia distributed some of the food in the soup/hotdish collection to make way for newer items. Thank you Cynthia!

Discipleship – The New Orleans youth group has met its financial goal and surpassed it (\$15,095). Any extra money will be saved toward next year. Confirmation ends on May 29 th . Youth taking treats to the SOS using the money won at chili/soup challenge.

Fellowship – Provided lunch for Laurentian Conference. Will be serving cake and ice cream for Senior Sunday (May 5th) when we honor our graduating seniors.

Will be putting on program for FELW for their spring luncheon on how to assemble a charcuterie board.

Building and Grounds - Lloyd submitted the following report:

Roof inspection from range roofing was positive We should have no trouble

going another year. Quote for new roof is right at \$50,000.

We may need to continue with roof tar over the front entrance for the immediate future.

We are preparing a list of jobs to be completed during our workday of June 8 th So far we have the following:

Pull down ladders.

Window washing

Painting

Handrail maintenance (sand blasting around the rust and painting)

Tree Trimming

Addressing water marks on main entrance ceiling tiles.

Sorting out hazardous waste in maintenance room

The work would run from 10:00 a.m. until 4:00 p.m. and is weather dependent. With a Barbecue thrown in sometime.

We will like champions for many of the tasks and then supplement with volunteers.

Let us check for additional items to be completed. Kitchen clean up? Fridge cleaning etc.

AED training for the council is planned. The AED was purchased and donated by Bill Mio and is much appreciated.

Finance: The \$135,000 CD is due in several months. Do we want to go for another 7 months at a rate of 5.05% which would earn us \$5,000 in interest or cash it in? The council agreed as there was no immediate need for the money that we should let it continue.

Music & Worship: Rachel explained that due to many commitments throughout the next month she would not be fully able to assume her duties for worship and music until May. She also asked the council to consider allowing her to hold a mental health awareness workshop and would donate a portion of the proceeds to the church. She was asked to submit a written outline of her proposal for council consideration at a future meeting.

Old Business:

1. Ft Frances visit – went well. Zion Ft Frances council met and sent a letter expressing interest in discussing pastoral services. Discussion about determining what their needs/desires were and Pastor Christie
(Council continued on page 6)



Charcuterie presentation a success at gathering

Brenda Bertilson read a devotion titled “Fear Not!” from a *Guidepost* magazine.

The Mission and Purpose statements were read. Minutes from the April 2024 meeting were read and approved.

Old business:

Those who attended the Women’s Gathering April 27, 2024, enjoyed a delicious lunch and good fellowship. Thank you to Cynthia Warren for her fun presentation of the charcuterie board; thank you to her husband for making and donating the beautiful wood board, which was the first door prize.

Thank you to Theresa Waller, who also donated a

board for the second door prize.

The summer convention was discussed. It was voted on to pay the full amount for three FLW members to attend. Motion carried.

New Business:

The July bazaar has a new name: “Crazy Day’s Bake Sale at First Lutheran Church”. It will be the same day as the city’s Crazy Days and will run from 10:00 a.m. to 1 p.m. Coffee and a dessert will be available for a price.

Next meeting is June 18, 2024 at 5:00 p.m.

Respectfully submitted,
Sandy Harju, Secretary

The FELW are trying a new type of fundraiser in July this year!

**A Crazy Days Bake Sale
is scheduled for
Wednesday, July 31!!
10 a.m.— 1 p.m.**

**Coffee and a sweet
treat will also be
offered for purchase.**



(Council, continued from page 4)

should list what she felt were the most important items of ministry and then we will meet with them. We do not have to do everything at once but start with the most important.

We do not want to overextend Pastor. Pastor says she has already thought about logistics – how to get across bridge quickly during tourist season, for instance, and she will make up the list as asked, We will then give several dates to Zion on which we could meet. Discussion about having a communication body to make sure all info goes to everyone.

2. Letter to Zion – I. Falls was sent. Pastor also met with the head of their council, and they understand our decision. If there are any questions asked of you, feel free to refer them to Pastor.

3. Parish Nurse – FELW has donated \$1,000 directly to Kathi to use for expenses of the program.

New Business:

1. Church workday – Will be on June 8th ,

weather permitting. If you see any other needed tasks around church, take a pic so people will know what needs to be done.

2. Administrative Professionals Day – April 24th . Certificates for massage will be given to both secretaries and Pastor is treating them to lunch.

3. Employee Evals – time for employee evaluations. Pastor, Brian and Carol will do them.

4. Retreat – Pastor needs a final tally of who will attend the retreat to let camp know as to food and accommodations. Itinerary will be sent to everyone in early May.

5. Cynthia asked if anyone had ever considered having a pavilion on the grounds. It would be a good place to sit during outdoor activities and maybe enjoy the planned pollinator garden.

Meeting adjourned at 6:00 p.m.

Next Executive Meeting: Tuesday, May 14th at 5 p.m.

Next Council Meeting: Saturday, May 18th at Camp Vermillion retreat

Respectfully submitted by: Carol Bass, Secretary



**AED training in
Memorial Hall**

Come to the Summer "Sunrise" service!



We know that summer is so much fun, but let's face it, sometimes it gets really busy! Having fun takes time and for that we give thanks! So, for those busy summer Sundays, we invite you to our Summer "Sunrise" worship service series! This weekly service in Memorial Hall will be focused on reflecting God's presence through spiritual practices each week. This service will include communion, prayers, music and litanies. While a sermon will not be preached at these services, our gospel will be read and there will be either quiet reflection or active discussion for participants to gain insight on how God is speaking. If you attended the noon Lenten lunch series it'll be similar to that.

This special summer service will begin each Sunday at 8:00 a.m. and will be finished by 8:45 a.m. It will begin June 9th and end on August 18th. This service will NOT be recorded or broadcast on our Facebook page.

We will continue to offer our "regular" 10:30 a.m. service with full liturgy and preaching. Come to one, come to both! We are excited to see you this summer!



First Lutheran Youth: What's Up?

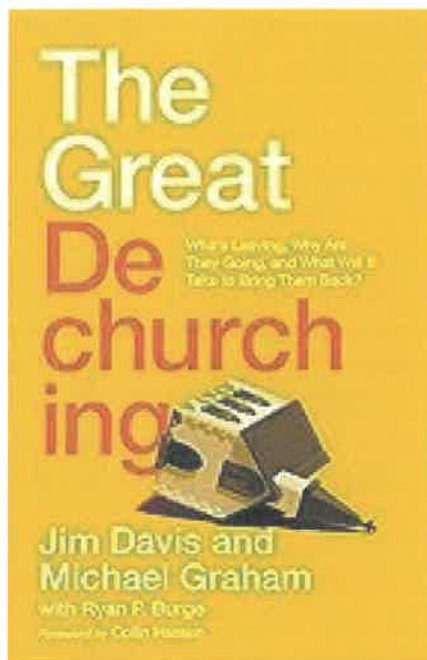


Four graduating seniors received scholarships from First Lutheran this year. Left to right are: Parker Olson, Garrett Froemke, and Jake Olson. Not pictured is Matt Burri.



Sixth and seventh grade confirmation classes from Zion and First visited some of the guests of Servants of Shelter with sandwiches and smiles.

Book recommendations



The Great DeChurching

By Jim Davis and Michael Graham

It is greater than the First and Second Great Awakening and every revival in our country combined...but in the opposite direction. Yet precious little rigorous study has been done on the broad phenomenon of dechurching in America.

Jim Davis and Michael Graham have commissioned the largest and most comprehensive study of dechurching in America by renowned sociologists Dr. Ryan Burge and Dr. Paul Djupe.

The Great Dechurching takes the insights gleaned from this study to drill down on how exactly people are dechurching with respect to beliefs, behavior, and belonging. This book gives the church in America its first ever deep dive into the dechurched phenomenon.

You'll learn about the dechurched through a detailed sketch of demographics, size, core concerns, church off-ramps, historical roots, and the gravity of what is at stake.

Then you'll explore what can be done to slow the bleed, engage the pertinent issues winsomely and wisely, and hopefully re-church some of the dechurched.

This book can be borrowed from the church office. Ask Pastor Christie for a copy.



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Did you know... If you are a Thrivent member, you can contribute to First Lutheran Church through Thrivent Choice Dollars and Thrivent Actions Teams. Log into your Thrivent account online, call 1-800-847-4836 or speak with your personal Thrivent representative for more information.

let's be friends



@FIRSTLUTHERANC



FIRST LUTHERAN CHURCH
ELCA

Vacation Bible School at First
June 10-14, 8:30—11:30.
Mark your calendars!!



To those who helped with worship in May, including: Carol Bass, Ardel Henrickson, Makenna Welchel, Grace Weisz, Steve and Laurie Lindberg, Don Nuthak, Maureen Jackson, Kallie Briggs, Kathi Henrickson, Kitty Sandstrom.

To those who helped with fellowship, including: Sherri Mannausau, and all the others behind the scenes.

To those who helped with music: Kris Jackson, Sue Hewitt, Brad Ettestad, Lynn Salo, Rachel Hasbargen-Glowack, and Kathy Thureen.

Prayer Chain

First Lutheran Church has four active prayer chains. If you have prayer requests for someone, or yourself, call either the church office at 283-2208, or Brenda Bertilson 283-2144; 240-4939. You must have permission to put someone on the chain, either from the person, or from a close relative. To put someone on the list for Sunday prayers, call the office at 283-2208. People will be on the list for one week only, unless you ask that they remain on the list. In that case, please call back when they can be removed.

Remember in your prayers, those in need and those in care facilities.

Good Samaritan: Jackie Christiansen, Margi Roeder, Ruby Radford, Lorraine Nelson, Barb (Strandberg) Wichner, Kathy Miggins

Littlefork Nursing Home: Dick Bergh, Russel Millender

Northwinds Assisted Living: Vicki Freeberg, Terry Lucachick, Henry Carey

Ranier Roost: Ruth Millender

General Fund Financial Information

As of April 30, 2024

Thank you for supporting First Lutheran Church!

	Current Month Actual	Current Month Budget	Variance		Year To Date Actual	Year To Date Budget	Variance
Operating Income	10,016	15,891	(5,875)		59,997	63,564	(3,567)
Operating Expense	16,510	15,891	(619)		61,220	63,564	2,344
Operating Income Less Expense	(6,494)	0	(6,494)		(1,223)	0	(1,223)

June Birthdays

6/1 Pacey Rousseau
6/3 Hazel Aasen
Joseph Glowack
6/4 Hannah Cook
Fred Smith
6/6 Tim Heinle
Steve Lindberg
Tara Long
Laurie Olsen
Charley Swanson
6/8 Ashley Shipley
6/9 Landon Basaraba
Lauren Basaraba
6/10 Terry Bounds
6/11 Stephanie Heinle
Robert Johnson
6/15 Jodi Herberg
Whitney Bartholmy
Nancy Johnson
Carissa Shipley
6/16 Christopher Steinbach
6/18 Savannah Olson
James Wood
6/19 Walter Green

6/20 Kole Bernath
Carlene Blair
6/21 Adam Bergstrom
6/22 Ardel Henrickson
Courtney Klow
6/24 Clay Bergstrom
Justin Shipley
6/25 Grace Haanen
Will Haanen
6/27 Barb Albert
6/29 Hunter Sobkowicz
6/30 Catherine Christensen



**Vacation Bible School at First
June 10-14, 8:30–11:30.
Mark your calendars!!**

**BACKUS COMMUNITY CAFE SERVES
FREE, HOT MEALS TO EVERYONE**

Thank you to May's volunteers: Laurie Lindberg, Nancy Johnson,
Brenda Bertilson, and Carol Bass.

FIRST EVANGELICAL LUTHERAN CHURCH, ELCA
123 Wayside Lane
International Falls, MN 56649

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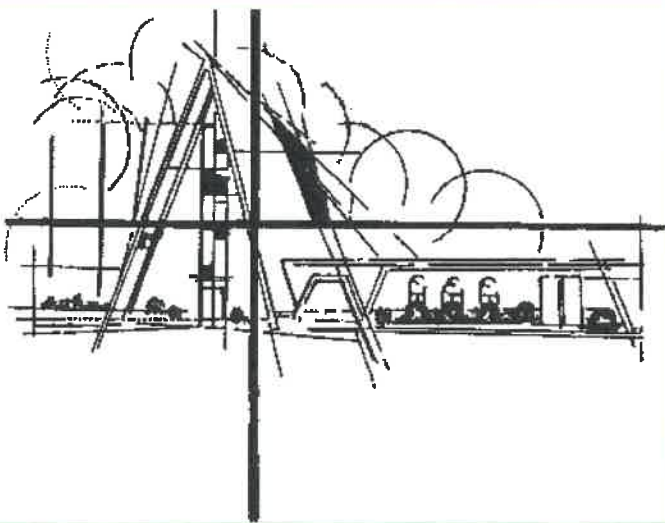
June 2024
NEWSLETTER

(CHANGE SERVICE REQUESTED)



First Evangelical Lutheran Church, ELCA

WHEREVER YOU ARE ON YOUR JOURNEY, YOU ARE WELCOME HERE!



First Lutheran's Mission Statement *Sharing God's Grace*

First Lutheran's Vision Statement
*First Lutheran Church will be a congregation
that shares God's grace by:*

- + Proclaiming the gospel of Jesus Christ with integrity.
- + Welcoming all to active involvement in ministry.
- + Offering a non-judgmental encounter with God through the celebration of liturgical worship with word and sacrament.
- + Responding faithfully to the Great Commission of Matthew 28 -- to grow.
- + Committing ourselves to serving the needs of our congregation and the community at large.

WORSHIP SERVICE

Available on our website, YouTube, and Facebook
Sundays at 10:30 a.m.

OFFICE HOURS

Mon. through Thurs., 10 a.m. to 2 p.m.
Office: 218-283-2208

Check out our Website!

www.firstlutheranifalls.org

Look for us on Instagram and Facebook.